

Even without formal office, Diem remained a key figure in nationalist politics over the next two decades and was recognized as a potential future leader. In 1945 and 1949, he turned down invitations to become prime minister under Bao Dai, in regimes that were compromised by association with the Japanese or the French. He also refused Ho Chi Minh's invitation to join the government of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam in 1946. Diem had personal reasons to distrust the Viet Minh; its activists had killed one of his brothers and once held Diem himself under duress.

After the outbreak of the First Indochina War, Diem sought to lead a "third force" in Vietnamese politics, made up of nationalists who also rejected communism. His activities antagonized both sides. Threatened with assassination by the Viet Minh, Diem soon found that the French authorities were unwilling to provide him with protection. In 1950, he sought safety abroad, first in Europe and then in the United States. Partly exploiting his Catholic connections, he endeavored to establish links with important US political figures, including Senator John F. Kennedy, and with the CIA.

Nepotistic leader

When the French declared Vietnam independent in June 1954, Diem was able to dictate his own terms for accepting the post of prime minister from Bao Dai. Backed by the Can Lao party and its secret police—run by his brother Ngo Dinh Nhu—Diem was quick to oust Bao Dai and stamp his own authority on South Vietnam.

The United States provided plentiful support to a man who seemed capable of saving the South from communism, but their influence over his behavior was limited. Proclaiming an ideology of "personalism," Diem built his regime around family loyalty. His brother Ngo Dinh Nhu and Nhu's wife—South Vietnam's de facto "First Lady"—joined Diem in the presidential palace. Another of his brothers, Ngo Dinh Thuc—the archbishop of Hue—also proved a powerful ally.

Diem also cultivated the support of the Catholic minority, swelled by refugees from the North. However, some 90 percent of South Vietnam's population was Buddhist.